

Outlier vs the strategy houses: McKinsey, BCG and Bain

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McKinsey, BCG and Bain are often called the MBB firms. For decades they have been the first call for chief executives facing a defining decision. Today each of them has a dedicated AI capability, and each of them publishes some of the most widely read research on how companies adopt AI.

If you lead a boutique firm of 50 to 100 people, you may wonder whether you need that level of firepower to get AI right. This article explains how the strategy houses approach AI, what they do exceptionally well, and why a partnership of your size is often better served by The Outlier.

We will be fair. The strategy houses are excellent. They are simply designed for a different client. In the language of the old Mac and PC adverts: they are the powerful machine in the corner office of a global corporation. We are the Mac on the desk of the partner who actually has to make it work on Monday.

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insey and QuantumB

McKinsey's AI arm is QuantumBlack. It was founded in London in 2009, acquired by McKinsey in 2015, and had grown to more than 1,000 practitioners by 2022 (Consultancy.uk). QuantumBlack combines data scientists, engineers and designers with McKinsey's industry consultants (McKinsey, QuantumBlack). Its annual State of AI survey is one of the most cited sources on enterprise AI adoption (McKinsey, The state of AI).

and B

BCG launched BCG X in December 2022 as a tech build and design unit, bringing together nearly 3,000 technologists, scientists, engineers and designers (Consultancy.com.au). In April 2026, BCG reported revenue of US\$14.4 billion for 2025, a global headcount of about 33,500, and said that AI and technology work made up more than 40% of its revenue (BCG press release).

n and its OpenAI alli

Bain announced a global services alliance with OpenAI in February 2023, combining its strategy and implementation work with OpenAI's tools (Bain press release). The firm describes itself as working across 67 cities in 40 countries (Bain, About).

These are real strengths. The strategy houses attract exceptional talent, they see patterns across hundreds of large clients, and they can stand up a team of specialists almost anywhere in the world. When a global retailer needs to rethink its whole operating model around AI, few organisations are better equipped.

size changes the experi

The strategy houses are built around a model that has served them well for a long time. A small group of senior partners frames the problem and owns the client relationship. Teams of consultants, often early in their careers, do much of the analysis. Harvard Business Review described this classic pyramid in 2025 and argued that AI is pushing consulting toward leaner, more senior-heavy teams (HBR). That transition is underway, but it reshapes large firms slowly.

For a boutique partnership, the classic model tends to create friction in a few places. These are general patterns across the industry and our own view, not statements about any specific engagement:

None of this is a flaw. It is what makes those firms work at their scale. It just does not match what a partnership of 50 to 100 people needs.

The Outlier w

The Outlier exists for one type of client: boutique firms of 50 to 100 people in advisory, mobility, HR, legal and recruitment. We do not deliver strategy decks. We deliver systems that work.

senior person, from first interview to working sy

Our founder, Fariza Sbaa, spent nearly two decades in HR, Global Mobility, Governance, Compliance and Transformation at ING Bank, Heineken International and Media.Monks. She has seen how corporate transformation works from the inside, including the parts that never make it into the case study. At The Outlier, she is the person in the room. She interviews your partners, maps your workflows and designs the roadmap. Nothing gets lost in a hand-off.

gnosis in two w

The AI Friction Scan takes two weeks and costs a fixed €2,750. We interview three to five partners and five to eight people on the floor, map your three heaviest workflows, such as proposals, onboarding or file building, and score each opportunity by time saved and payback period. You get a one-page roadmap and a one-hour presentation to the partnership.

ategy and build in one

The strategy houses separate thinking from doing because their scale demands it. We do not. After the scan, the AI Systems Sprint (€12,500, 8 to 12 weeks, or Sprint Light at €7,500) builds one system that speeds up your core process, inside Microsoft 365, Google Workspace or your CRM. Your people are trained, the system is documented, and we measure hours saved before and after.

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Every format has a published price. No day rates that drift, no scope that quietly grows. If you need ongoing leadership, the Fractional AI Transformation Partner starts at €2,750 per month for two days a month at your management table.

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Your clients pay for judgement. We design AI to take the repetitive work away from your experts, so they can spend more time on the work only they can do.

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| | Strategy houses | The Outlier |

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| Built for | Global corporations and their boards | Boutique firms of 50 to 100 people |

| Core output | Strategy, often followed by a build unit | A diagnosis and a working system |

| Who you work with | Partner-led teams of consultants | The senior founder, hands on |

| First result | Depends on scope | Two-week AI Friction Scan |

| Pricing | Scoped per engagement | Fixed, published prices |

| Benchmarks | Hundreds of large enterprises | The dynamics of partnerships |

| Reach | Dozens of countries | NL and BE, expanding to Europe and the UAE |

n a strategy house is the right ch

Honesty first. A strategy house is the right call if you face a question that goes far beyond AI: a merger, a market exit, a full redesign of a multinational operating model. It is the right call if your board needs the comparative data that only comes from studying hundreds of large companies. It is the right call if you are building a proprietary AI product that needs dozens of data scientists for a year. And it is often the right call if a private equity owner already works with one of these firms and wants continuity.

In those cases, their scale is exactly what you are paying for.

n The Outlier is the better

The Outlier fits when your question is practical and close to home. Where does our firm lose time? Which AI systems pay for themselves within three months? How do we build them without hiring a department? Who sits at our table and owns the AI agenda when no one else has time?

Those questions do not need a global team. They need one experienced person who understands partnerships and who will still be there when the system goes live.

The corner-office machine is powerful. We are the Mac.

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Take the free assessment at /start to see where your firm stands. If a scan makes sense, the AI Friction Scan gives you clarity in two weeks for a fixed €2,750. If it does not, we will tell you that too.

Company names are trademarks of their respective owners. This comparison reflects publicly available information as of October 2026.